

Prologue

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When I told Kahlil I wanted to write the story of Dunya, at first he'd refused. He said he did not want to remember it. But as the years passed Kahlil began to realize that this was a story he could never forget. One whose words did not settle in the mind so much as they painted the soul in the colours of that world. And after so many years having spent away from it, I often wonder if I had ever even left. For Dunya is the world as it is; all that is good and all that is evil, whether you choose to believe in it or not—it cannot be escaped except with death. But I have lived long enough to see this Dunya change, the world left behind, stagnant, only to be given life once again. A great story can change the world, so I'll tell this one as best I can, through the eyes of those who had been there to see it.

And I'll begin by saying that there was nothing inherently special about Kahlil before he found himself in Dunya. If you had seen him then, your gaze would have passed over the neat waves of his hair and the faint glimmer of gold in his eyes, and you would have thought nothing much of him except that he was a mild-mannered, timorous boy, slightly distracted, perhaps even occasionally unruly if only to prove he wasn't afraid of the world, though he was, terribly afraid. I say this only to give you an impression of the kind of boy he was, so that you may better understand the kind of man he became. However,

I'm afraid I'd be doing this story an injustice if I didn't speak of his parents, his mother, most of all, for it was with her, as well as without, that Kahlil's adolescent identity was formed, and through it, his infatuation with an older girl by the name of Mary Ann, whose sudden disappearance would then fuel a lifetime of longing—the foundation upon which this story can be told.

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His mother was Nour Al-Ashkar, born in 1970 in Tartus Syria, and named for the remarkable radiance of her face, the thick golden locks of hair, and the brilliant blue eyes with just a few flecks of gold in the irises. At her birth, the doctor said he had never seen such a bright and jovial baby, and all the nurses agreed that it was as if this girl had fought a great battle just to be born, and was so utterly relieved at having won, that all she could do was laugh in the face of the doctor as he lifted her, a laugh that he would remember for all his life.

Nour became a most precious child to all who saw her and knew her family, not only because of her ineffable beauty which was so remarkably like her mother's, but also because of the rather unexpected circumstances from which she was born. Her mother was forty when she became pregnant, her father fifty-five. They had no previous children, though not from want of trying. The doctors said it had something to do with an autoimmune disease, though it didn't matter what it was; it rarely does for the poor. So when Nour's mother became pregnant at last, after nearly twenty years of trying, it was as if all her prayers had been replied to, all at once, and what a cruel twist of fate that the answers had killed her. The child grew slowly inside her, twisting and turning, entangling itself in its umbilical cord, kicking and punching. There were times, during the final few days when she could almost hear her daughter struggling for life within her, bickering and battling with death that it should not take her so early in life. But while Nour had been laughing with relief at having finally been born, her mother had been struck by a deep melancholy which lingered and never left. She grew sullen, emaciated, like a doll in the way she cradled her child. She could not breastfeed, nor did she try. Her husband would come home to find her sitting at the window, staring blankly at a boat rocking in the distant sea while the baby lay shrieking in the crib behind her. She died three months later, leaving for Nour

only the memory of her at the window, a willowy silhouette of long golden hair.

Her father was left with the task of raising her alone. He took charge of her education, but as he could not afford to send her to school, his widowed mother offered to move in and educate the child. Of her father, Nour saw only what he let her; a happy man no matter what befell him, for he wanted nothing more than his daughter's health and happiness. But as she grew she began to notice the hidden ache of the old man's heart, the twitch of his jaw from the decades of clenching, the deep bags under his eyes, how his spine leaned when he stood in prayer, and she felt herself powerless to help him. Her jovial spirit carried well into womanhood, accentuated by an intellect that matched her beauty, which, as she grew, only garnered more and more attention, most of which was cruel and envious. But Nour never became proud or pompous, and despite the evident jealousy from the other girls, they could not help but admire her modest nature, and she became quite popular despite her status as a home-schooled shutaway.

At 19, as she sat outside the ministry building where she had been sent by her grandmother to await her aunt and her husband, for she was to have tea with them (they had just come back from abroad and wanted to speak to her of marriage), she met a man on the steps to the ministry. I don't know much about this man; Kahlil refused to say any more than what I'm about to recall for you now, which, notably, does not include his name. He was the kind of man who was important by appearance alone; handsome, with a square jaw and a strong, protruding brow, and he stood proudly at the entrance, smiling at her from under the beating sun. She learned he had built himself and his wealth from nothing, that he had made his money buying land and building homes in the early deserts of the Emirates. He pursued her for several months, showing up unexpectedly to tea and late dinners to the delight of all who knew him, for in him all they saw were their desires reflected back at them; a chance to be people, to be free. But Nour did not see him as anything other than the caricature of a businessman. Even as he spoke of his plans for his future in that gentle, slippery voice, and later asked her father for her hand, she always sensed that this person was merely the insinuation of a man, and that if all the money in the world were to disappear in the morning, she would wake up to find he'd gone with it. For the price of Nour's hand, the man offered her father an estate in Damascus, with servants, workers, a courtyard, and acres of land for the farming of

grain. In the end, of course, the decision was Nour's, as everyone was so eager to remind her. But she could see in all their vehement eyes and trembling lips, that she had about as much choice in the matter as a kitten taken from the street for adoption. She could be fed anything she wanted, and have anything she asked for, though she wanted nothing more than the bread her grandmother baked every morning, and she asked for nothing more than her father's happiness and rest. She may or may not have wanted this adoption (I believe she didn't even know herself), but it didn't matter.

Out of the love for her father, Nour convinced herself that she loved this man just as much, and in fact, she was so good at this, that she began to see him as more than merely her husband, but a man worthy of worship. He was such a handsome, successful man, the envy of the town, of even the city. He knew so much more than she did. He read so many books and knew so many people. Her love for him grew with every moment they spent both together and apart, reaching such heights that she began to postpone her prayers so she could spend more time with him, and to question her beliefs whenever he challenged them, which was quite often, until he'd exhausted every ounce of faith she ever had, leaving but a husk of herself, lost and dependant solely on the moods and whims of this man whom she had replaced God with. Kahlil was born only a year after the marriage, at the end of one of the coldest winters in recent history, and after an excruciating labour that lasted nearly a week and planted the thought of death in the minds of all who knew her. It seemed to many at the time, that Nour's son had fought just as hard as she had to be born, if not more so, and they wondered during the long nights of that week, why God had brought this family so near to death for something as abundant as life. But these questions have no answers, although not many can content themselves with the mystery of God's will. I certainly did not.

End of sneak peek

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